

Giuseppe Domenico Scarlatti was born in Naples in 1685—an auspicious year that also saw the birth of J.S. Bach and Handel. He was a child of opera composer Alessandro Scarlatti (see [box](#)), who had his son appointed organist at the Neapolitan royal chapel at the age of 15. Although Domenico showed exceptional ability as a keyboard player, his father insisted he write vocal music, and his first opera was performed in Naples in 1703.

In 1709, Scarlatti obtained a post as in-house composer for Queen Maria Casimira of Poland, who was living in exile in Rome. Over the following five years, he wrote seven operas for the queen's theater and also established a reputation as a harpsichord virtuoso.

Royal duties

In 1715, Scarlatti was appointed maestro di cappella at St. Peter's, the position [Palestrina](#) had once held, but he was increasingly frustrated by his subjection to his father's authority and by being forced to focus on vocal music. In 1719, he accepted an invitation to join the royal court of Portuguese King Joao V in Lisbon. One of his duties was to teach music to the king's nine-year-old daughter, Princess María Bárbara de Bragança. When she married the future king of Spain in 1729, Scarlatti accompanied her to Seville and then to Madrid, where he lived at the court for the rest of his life.